The survivability of India's arsenal and therefore the credibility of its retaliation depend on an array of factors beyond the numbers – most fundamentally, advance warning of an incoming attack, the dispersal of the weapons, their mobility or their safety in hardened silos, the survival of command-and-control systems, and the numbers, size, and accuracy of the attacker's nuclear weapons. If India has taken the necessary precautions, its arsenal should be secure despite China's lead in numbers of weapons. India's nuclear forces can bolster its conventional forces. Nuclear weapons have been called the great equalizers because they can compensate for the lack of sufficient conventional weapons. If China were to threaten to overwhelm Indian defences on either land or sea, it must worry about the possibility of nuclear weapons being used to stop its forces.

Four Caveats . . . And a Final Comparison

While China certainly has greater military power than India, its ability to coerce or defeat India appears limited for the reasons given earlier: geography and strategy. However, four caveats are important.

The first caveat is that logistics count. India's ability to defend itself depends on supplies of ammunition and other vital inputs and the ability to deliver those to the fighting arm in time and for the duration of the war. India has improved its infrastructure and its military transport, particularly for land warfare. Less is known about its stock of ammunition and related supplies. Understandably, the Indian government will not make public how long war supplies will last. Estimates vary, but in a recent assessment of a two-front war, the defence expert Sushant Singh reports that in case of an 'intense' war with Pakistan, India has sufficient stocks for ten days' fighting. With China, the Indian military expects to fight for up to thirty days.[28] If a war with China becomes a two-front war, with Pakistan opening another front in Kashmir, then Indian defences will be stretched and its supplies perilous. That India's logistics are wafer-thin is in part because it depends on foreign supplies, particularly for key weapon systems.